



WORDPRESS PLUGIN · USER GUIDE

MBR Cookie Consent

Enterprise-grade consent management for WordPress — global privacy law coverage, script and embed blocking that survives a page cache, settings portability, and 22 community translations. Genuinely free.

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This revision covers versions 2.3.4 and 2.3.5. Sections 12, 13, 17, 18, 19 and 22 have changed materially since the v2.3.3 guide.

1. Introduction

MBR Cookie Consent is a complete, professional-grade consent management platform for WordPress — and it is entirely free. No premium tier, no upsells, no monthly fees, and no third-party branding forced onto your banner.

It was built on a simple frustration: privacy compliance had become something businesses were expected to pay hundreds of pounds a year for, often in exchange for a banner that displayed someone else's logo. This plugin takes the opposite view. Every feature you would expect from an enterprise consent platform is included in the free version, fully documented, and yours to configure however your site needs.

What this plugin does

- Displays a customisable, accessible consent banner that respects the visitor's choices.
- Blocks non-essential scripts and tracking until the visitor gives explicit consent.
- Adjusts automatically to the visitor's region, applying the correct privacy law.
- Integrates with Google Consent Mode v2 and Microsoft UET.
- Blocks form submissions server-side until consent is granted — even with JavaScript disabled.
- Keeps an exportable, audit-ready record of every consent interaction.
- Generates a privacy policy, including the AI training disclosure now required in Connecticut.
- Blocks click-to-play video facades created by performance plugins, and their poster images.
- Shows the banner in the visitor's own language, in 22 community-contributed translations.
- Works correctly behind a page cache, which most consent plugins quietly do not.
- Exports and imports its own configuration, so one tuned setup can be rolled out across many sites.
- Works across single sites and full WordPress Multisite networks.

New in version 2.3.5

A correctness release. Two faults where a settings screen reported the opposite of what the site was doing, one remaining page-cache problem, and a hardening change to the consent log.

The WCAG/ADA switch now works

Enable WCAG/ADA Compliance Features would not stay on. Ticking it and saving returned a page with the box clear again, which looked exactly like the save had failed. It could not be turned off either: the accessibility features carried on running while the screen reported them as switched off. The setting was stored as a word rather than a yes/no value, and neither the checkbox nor the front-end check recognised it. It now saves, displays and applies correctly in both directions.

Note

Sites updating from an earlier version are set to **on**. That is what they were actually doing, whatever the screen showed, so nothing changes on your site — the display simply becomes truthful. If you genuinely want the accessibility layer off, you can now untick it and it will stay unticked.

A/B testing now survives a page cache

The banner variant was chosen on the server and written into the page. On a cached site that meant whichever visitor happened to generate the stored copy had their variant baked into it, and everyone served that copy afterwards saw the same one. Impressions were recorded against the cached variant rather than the visitor's, so the figures measured the cache rather than the test.

Variants are now assigned in the browser and the page is identical for every visitor. This was the last part of the document that still varied by visitor on the server. See section 19.

Consent log fingerprint salted

Each consent record carries a fingerprint of the visitor's IP address and browser identification string. It was an unsalted SHA-256, and both inputs are drawn from a small enough range that anyone holding an exported log could recover the original address by trying every possibility. It is now keyed with a per-site salt that never leaves your server. See section 18.

Other changes

- **Promoting an A/B winner** wrote an invalid banner setting. Variants B and C stored a layout name in the position setting, a combination the appearance picker cannot represent, so it showed no layout selected and the next save on that screen quietly reset it. Promotion now writes a matching position and layout, and purges the cache.
- **Geolocation provider terms.** The Geolocation screen now warns that IP lookup services are third parties with their own licensing, and that free tiers are generally offered for non-commercial or development use. See section 12.
- **Privacy law notes refreshed to August 2026**, including a corrected ePrivacy Regulation withdrawal date and several US state amendments. See section 13.

New in version 2.3.4

Regional banners had never fully worked, and the last of the page-cache faults were removed.

- **Regional settings now reach the banner.** Each region carried a dozen settings — its own wording, whether a Reject button was required, how categories behaved — and the banner read three of them. A visitor in the UK saw much the same banner as a visitor anywhere else. The geolocation test tool did read them all, which made this hard to spot: it reported behaviour, confidently and in detail, that the banner had never implemented. The tool now reports only what the banner actually does.
- **Region detection moved into the browser.** The region was decided on the server and written into the page, so on a cached site a visitor in the United States could prime the cache with a banner carrying no Reject button, which was then served to visitors in the EU.
- **The 'Do Not Sell or Share' link could be shown to everyone**, for the same reason — it was switched on from the visitor's GPC signal while the page was being built.
- **Page exclusions did not exclude script blocking.** An excluded page still had its third-party scripts held, with nothing on the page offering to release them, so a first-time visitor landing there had no way to consent at all. Excluded pages now show the floating Cookie Settings button.
- **Removed: Google Additional Consent Mode.** The option existed and the class existed, but no AC String was ever generated, stored or sent. Enabling it added an empty callback to your pages and nothing else. Google Consent Mode v2 is unaffected.
- **The consent cookie is now percent-encoded.** It holds JSON, so it contained commas, braces and quotes — characters a cookie value is not supposed to carry. Cookies written by earlier versions are still read, so nobody is asked to consent again.
- **Geolocation could silently never run.** The settings screen defaulted to one lookup provider while the lookup itself defaulted to another, so on sites where the geolocation screen had never been saved no lookup happened at all.

Important

If you generated a privacy policy while Google Additional Consent Mode was enabled, regenerate it. Google Ad Manager was listed in the services section purely because that option was ticked.

New in version 2.3.3

The largest correctness release the plugin has had. Script and iframe blocking, Google and Microsoft Consent Mode, and Global Privacy Control were all decided on the server from the visitor's cookie, which cannot be made safe behind a page cache. All three were moved into the browser. Click-to-play video facades are now recognised and held, automatic translation was rebuilt so that it genuinely works, and the non-functional IAB TCF v2.3 feature was removed.

Important

If you generated a privacy policy while IAB TCF was enabled, regenerate it. It stated that your site participates in the Transparency and Consent Framework, which was not accurate.

2. Requirements & Compatibility

MBR Cookie Consent is designed to run comfortably on standard WordPress hosting. Before installing, confirm your environment meets the minimums below.

Requirement	Minimum	Recommended
WordPress	5.8	6.5 or newer
PHP	7.4	8.1 or newer
MySQL / MariaDB	5.7 / 10.3	8.0 / 10.6 or newer
HTTPS	Strongly advised	Required for accurate consent records

Note

Earlier revisions of this guide listed WordPress 6.0 as the minimum. The plugin has always supported 5.8, and from version 2.3.2 the update manifest declares 5.8 as well. Before that the manifest asked for WordPress 6.0 and PHP 8.0, which meant sites on older versions were never offered an update at all.

Tested integrations

- **Page builders:** Elementor, plus the standard WordPress block editor.
- **Form plugins:** Contact Form 7, WPForms, Gravity Forms, Elementor Forms.
- **Multilingual:** WPML and Polylang.
- **Caching:** SiteGround Speed Optimizer, WP Rocket, LiteSpeed, W3 Total Cache, WP Super Cache, WP Fastest Cache, WP-Optimize, Cache Enabler, Breeze, Nginx Helper and WP Engine are purged automatically on save. See section 22.

Important

If you also run MBR WP Performance or another optimisation plugin that defers or delays JavaScript, read the note on script ordering in section 24 before going live. Consent scripts must load early enough to block trackers on the first view.

3. Installation & Activation

Installing the plugin

- Download the latest `mbr-cookie-consent.zip` from littlewebshack.com.
- In your WordPress admin, go to **Plugins › Add New › Upload Plugin**.
- Choose the downloaded ZIP file and select **Install Now**.
- When installation finishes, select **Activate**.

First activation

On activation the plugin creates its database tables for consent logging and registers a new admin menu, **MBR Cookie Consent**. A default banner configuration is applied immediately so your site is never left without a banner while you finish setting up.

Tip

Updating from an earlier version is safe — your settings and consent records are preserved. Version 2.3.5 repairs the WCAG setting, 2.3.3 runs a one-off repair on text settings damaged by an escaping bug, and 2.3.0 deliberately left your existing regional behaviour untouched. Always take a routine backup before any plugin update, as you would with any change to a live site.

4. Quick Start: Compliant in Five Minutes

The following sequence gets a typical site to a compliant, working state quickly. Each step is expanded in its own section later in this guide.

Step 1 — Run the cookie scanner

Open **MBR Cookie Consent › Scanner** and run a one-click scan. The plugin crawls your pages and lists the scripts and iframes it finds, suggesting a category for each.

Step 2 — Confirm your categories

Review the detected items under Necessary, Analytics, Marketing and Preferences. Adjust any that were placed in the wrong category.

Step 3 — Set your region behaviour

Under **Compliance**, enable geolocation so visitors are shown the banner that matches their jurisdiction. Set a sensible default region while you are there — it is what visitors see if detection cannot resolve their location.

Step 4 — Style the banner

In **Appearance**, set your colours, choose your logo from the Media Library, and pick a layout. Use the **Preview banner** button to see the result at desktop and mobile widths before you save.

Step 5 — Publish and test

Save, then visit your site in a private browsing window. Confirm the banner appears, that rejecting consent blocks the relevant scripts, and that the floating revisit button reopens the preferences.

Note

Always test in a private / incognito window. A normal window may already hold a stored consent choice from earlier testing, which hides the banner and makes it look as though nothing is happening.

5. The Consent Banner

The banner is the visitor's first point of contact with your consent settings. It is designed to be clear, fast, and fully accessible.

Banner actions

Action	What it does
Accept All	Grants consent to every category and unblocks all scripts.
Reject All	Declines all non-essential categories; only necessary cookies run.
Customise	Opens the Preference Centre for category-by-category control.

Banner behaviour

- Until a choice is made, all non-essential scripts remain blocked by default.
- The visitor's choice is stored and respected on subsequent visits.
- A floating revisit button lets visitors reopen and change their choice at any time.
- Consent can be set to expire after a defined period, prompting re-confirmation.
- On HTTPS sites the consent cookie is marked Secure, so it is never sent in cleartext.

Important

Equal prominence between Accept and Reject is a requirement under several jurisdictions, including the EU and UK. The default banner gives Accept All and Reject All buttons of equal weight — avoid restyling one to be far more prominent than the other.

6. Banner Customisation

The Appearance area lets you make the banner look like a natural part of your site rather than a bolt-on. A live preview reflects each change as you make it.

What you can change

Option	Details
Layout	Choose the banner position and shape — for example a bottom bar, a corner box, or a centred modal.
Colours	Set background, text, button and accent colours to match your brand.
Custom text	Rewrite the banner heading, body copy and button labels in your own voice.
Logo	Choose an image from the Media Library, with a live preview and a Remove button, or paste a URL for a logo hosted elsewhere.
Glassmorphism	A frosted-glass effect for the banner, with Opacity and Blur sliders.
Dark mode	Off, follow the visitor's system setting, or always on.

Choosing a logo

The **Choose from Media Library** button sits above the URL field. Where WordPress has generated sizes for the image, the medium size is used rather than the full original — so a large upload is not sent to every visitor merely to be displayed at 150 pixels wide.

Glassmorphism and dark mode

The glass effect applies to the banner only. The Preference Centre is a dense, scrollable panel of category toggles and body copy, where translucency fights the reading rather than decorating it, so it stays on a solid surface — in dark mode too. Browsers without backdrop-filter support fall back to the solid colour automatically, as do visitors who have asked their system for reduced transparency.

Dark mode swaps only the banner surface and text. Your Accept and Reject button colours are kept, so your branding survives the switch.

The contrast readout

Beside the glassmorphism sliders is a live WCAG 2.1 contrast ratio. Rather than capping how transparent the banner may be, the settings screen composites your chosen banner colour, text colour and opacity over both a white and a black backdrop, and reports the worse of the two. If that figure passes, the banner is legible over any page behind it — which a fixed opacity limit cannot guarantee.

Previewing before you save

The **Preview banner** button opens the banner in a modal using the settings currently on screen, including unsaved changes, at both desktop and mobile widths. The preview is produced by the real front-end renderer rather than a separate mock-up, so it cannot drift from what visitors actually see.

Tip

Whatever colours you choose, keep text and buttons at a contrast ratio that meets WCAG 2.1 AA (at least 4.5:1 for normal text). The readout beside the sliders does this for you — treat anything below 4.5:1 as a problem to fix rather than a warning to dismiss.

7. Cookie Categories & the Preference Centre

Cookies and scripts are organised into four standard categories. The Preference Centre is where visitors turn each category on or off individually.

Category	Purpose	Blocked by default?
Necessary	Essential for the site to function; cannot be switched off.	No — always allowed
Analytics	Measurement and statistics, e.g. Google Analytics.	Yes
Marketing	Advertising and cross-site tracking.	Yes
Preferences	Remembering choices such as language or region.	Yes

The Preference Centre

- Each non-necessary category has a clear on/off control.
- A short description explains what each category is for, in plain language.
- Visitors can accept some categories and decline others, then save.
- Choices take effect immediately — scripts in declined categories stay blocked.

8. Cookie Scanner & Script Management

One-click scanning

The scanner crawls your site and detects the scripts and iframes that set cookies or load third-party resources. Each detected item is listed with a suggested category, ready for you to confirm or change.

Manual management

- Add a script or pattern by hand if the scanner cannot reach it (for example, scripts loaded only after login).
- Edit the category or matching rule for any detected item.
- Remove items you no longer use.

Note

From version 2.3.1 the scanner runs only against your own site, or the network on multisite, and verifies TLS certificates. Run it again whenever you add a new third-party service — a new analytics tag, chat widget, embedded video, or advertising pixel. Newly added trackers are not blocked until the plugin knows about them.

9. Automatic Script Blocking

This is the engine behind genuine compliance. Rather than simply hiding a banner, the plugin actively prevents non-essential scripts from running until the visitor has given consent for the relevant category.

How it works

- Every visitor is served the same page, with all non-necessary scripts and embeds held inert.
- The browser then releases whatever the visitor's stored choice permits.
- If consent is declined, those scripts never run, and no cookies they would set are written.
- Necessary scripts are never blocked, so core site functionality is unaffected.

Why the page is always blocked

Until version 2.3.3 the plugin decided what to block while building the page, by reading the visitor's consent cookie. That cannot be made safe on a cached site: the first visitor to accept everything caused an unblocked copy of the page to be stored, and everyone served that copy afterwards got the trackers running whatever they had chosen themselves.

Blocking now happens for everybody, without reference to any cookie, so the page is identical for every visitor and safe for a cache to store. The consequence worth knowing about is that a visitor who has accepted has their scripts released a moment after the page arrives rather than as it is parsed. This is how every mature consent platform works, and it is the only arrangement that is correct behind a cache.

Click-to-play video facades

Performance plugins commonly replace a video embed with a facade: a poster image and a placeholder holding the video address, with the real player built in JavaScript only when the visitor clicks. It is a good optimisation, and before 2.3.3 it defeated consent blocking entirely — there was no embed left in the page to hold.

Facades are now recognised and held in the same way as an ordinary embed, and released by the browser on consent. MBR Performance, SG Optimizer, WP Rocket and others are covered, since the plugin matches the technique rather than any one product.

Good to know

Poster images are held too. A facade avoids the video provider's cookies but still fetches its thumbnail, which sent the visitor's IP address to YouTube or Vimeo on page load whether or not they ever pressed play. A transparent placeholder stands in until consent, so the layout does not move.

Important

If you run a performance plugin with a video lazy-load or facade option, test an embed after updating: reject cookies and confirm the video is replaced by the blocked-content placeholder. This was a silent failure, so it is worth seeing it work rather than assuming.

10. Consent Mode Integration

For sites that use Google or Microsoft advertising and analytics, MBR Cookie Consent speaks their consent signalling languages directly, so your tags adjust their behaviour according to the visitor's choices.

Framework	What it covers
Google Consent Mode v2	Signals <code>ad_storage</code> , <code>analytics_storage</code> and the v2 ad-personalisation parameters to Google tags.
Microsoft UET Consent Mode	Passes consent state to the Microsoft Advertising Universal Event Tracking tag.

Setting it up

- Enable the relevant framework under **MBR Cookie Consent › Consent Mode**.
- Ensure your Google or Microsoft tags load through the plugin's blocking layer so the signals apply.
- Use Google Tag Assistant or the Microsoft UET Tag Helper to confirm the consent state is being received.

How the signal is sent

The page always declares a denied default, identical for every visitor, and the visitor's actual choice is sent as an update from their browser before any Google or Microsoft tag loads. This is what the Consent Mode specification asks for — the default establishes the pre-consent baseline and the update carries the decision — and it is also the only arrangement that survives a page cache.

Important

IAB TCF v2.3 was removed in 2.3.3, and Google Additional Consent Mode in 2.3.4. Neither ever functioned. Supporting TCF properly requires registration as a Consent Management Platform with IAB Europe. If you are a publisher running programmatic advertising and need TCF, you need a registered CMP — this plugin covers GDPR, UK, CCPA and the other regimes in section 13, none of which require it.

11. Form Builder Integration

This is the feature that sets MBR Cookie Consent apart. Most plugins block forms with JavaScript alone, which anyone can bypass by disabling JavaScript. This plugin enforces consent on the server.

Server-side enforcement

When a visitor submits a form before granting the required consent, the submission is intercepted on the server and held. Because the check happens server-side, it cannot be circumvented by turning off JavaScript or editing the page.

Supported builders

- Contact Form 7
- WPForms
- Gravity Forms
- Elementor Forms

The Elementor experience

- A clean dark overlay modal replaces inline error messages.
- The visitor is offered **Accept Cookies** or **Not Now**.
- On acceptance, the pending submission is re-sent automatically with all entered data intact — the visitor does not have to retype anything.

Tip

The automatic re-submission relies on capturing the original request so it can be replayed after consent. If you use a heavily customised form setup, test the full submit-block-accept-resubmit cycle before launch.

12. Geolocation & Regional Compliance

Different regions demand different consent models. Geolocation lets a single configuration serve the right experience to each visitor automatically.

Model	Typical regions	Banner behaviour
Opt-in	EU / EEA, United Kingdom, Switzerland, Quebec, Brazil, India, Vietnam, Indonesia, Nigeria, China, South Korea, Saudi Arabia, South Africa	Scripts blocked until the visitor actively accepts.
Opt-out	Much of the United States	Scripts may run, with a clear way to opt out / 'Do Not Sell'.
Notice	Canada (federal), Australia	Visitors are informed; behaviour follows local rules.

How the region is applied

From version 2.3.4 the region is resolved in the browser rather than on the server. The page itself is identical for every visitor — which is what makes it safe to cache — and the browser asks the site which region applies, then adjusts the banner wording and behaviour accordingly.

If the lookup cannot complete — the request is blocked, the provider is slow, or JavaScript is unavailable — the visitor simply sees the banner your own settings describe. The fallback is your configuration, not an empty banner.

Good to know

This replaced the last remaining case where a page cache could freeze one visitor's region into a page served to everybody. Earlier revisions of this guide carried a troubleshooting entry about the wrong region's banner appearing on some pages. That fault is gone.

Visitor IP Detection

Introduced in version 2.3.1. Working out a visitor's country starts with working out their IP address, and behind a proxy or CDN that means reading a forwarding header. The difficulty is that any visitor can send those headers themselves. Trusting them blindly meant a visitor could nominate their own IP address and so choose which privacy regime they were shown.

Mode	When to use it
Automatic (default)	Accepts Cloudflare's header only when the request genuinely arrived from a Cloudflare address. Cloudflare sites work with no configuration.

Mode	When to use it
Trusted proxies	You sit behind a known load balancer or CDN. Supply its addresses and only those are believed.
Direct	No proxy in front of the site. The connecting address is used and forwarding headers are ignored entirely.

Choosing a lookup provider

Three options are offered. **Cloudflare headers** need no outbound request at all, because your CDN has already resolved the country before the request reaches WordPress. **ipapi.co** is the default for everyone else: it is free and serves HTTPS. **ip-api.com** offers a higher free rate limit but only serves HTTPS on its paid tier.

Important

Check your provider's terms before going live. Both lookup services are third parties with their own licensing, and their free tiers are generally offered for non-commercial, testing or development use. Those terms change without notice. If this is a commercial site, confirm you are within your chosen provider's current terms — or use the Cloudflare option, which resolves the country from a header your CDN already sends and makes no outbound request. This warning is now shown on the Geolocation screen itself. *(New in 2.3.5.)*

Geolocation lookups do not run over plain HTTP by default. Over plain HTTP anyone able to observe the connection can rewrite the country returned — silently changing which privacy regime your visitors receive — while their IP addresses travel to a third party unencrypted.

The default region

Every country without a dedicated region falls back to a single **Rest of World** setting. From 2.3.0 that fallback is opt-in — no auto-accept, and a reject option always present. Existing sites were not changed by that update; the plugin wrote your previous behaviour into your settings explicitly, so your banner continued to behave exactly as it did.

How detection is cached

- A detected region is remembered per visitor IP address for 24 hours by default.
- If the lookup provider is unreachable, rate-limited or blocked by your host, the plugin falls back to the default region you configured.
- From version 2.2.1 that fallback is remembered for only a few minutes rather than the full period, so a temporary provider problem clears itself.
- From version 2.3.1 outbound lookups are capped per minute, so a traffic burst with cold caches cannot trip the provider's rate limit.

Important

Geolocation tells you where a visitor appears to be; it is not legal advice. If you operate in a regulated sector or are unsure which model applies to you, confirm your obligations with a qualified adviser.

13. Privacy Law Reference

As of August 2026, MBR Cookie Consent is built to help you meet the requirements of the major privacy regimes below. This table is a plain-language summary, not a statement of legal compliance for your specific circumstances.

Law / framework	Region	Consent model
GDPR	EU / EEA	Prior opt-in for non-essential cookies
UK DUA	United Kingdom	Opt-in, handled separately from EU GDPR
CCPA / CPRA	California, USA	Opt-out, with 'Do Not Sell or Share'
US state laws	24 states enacted, 20 in effect	Opt-out, varying by state
Quebec Law 25	Quebec, Canada	Express opt-in, French-language banner
revFADP	Switzerland	Opt-in, GDPR-equivalent
LGPD	Brazil	Opt-in for non-essential cookies
India DPDP Act	India	Notice and consent for personal data
Vietnam PDPL	Vietnam	Opt-in, granular per-purpose consent
Indonesia UU PDP	Indonesia	Opt-in, purpose-specific with easy withdrawal
Nigeria NDPA + GAID	Nigeria	Opt-in, prominent banner required
China PIPL	China	Opt-in; separate consent for transfers
South Korea PIPA	South Korea	Opt-in where cookies identify a person
Saudi Arabia PDPL	Saudi Arabia	Opt-in; consent is the default basis
South Africa POPIA	South Africa	Opt-in for direct marketing
Global Privacy Control	Browser-level signal	Honoured automatically as an opt-out

Important

China needs work beyond the banner. PIPL requires a separate, standalone consent for transferring personal information outside mainland China, plus an approved transfer mechanism. This plugin provides neither. If you have meaningful traffic from mainland China, treat the China region as a starting point and take advice on the transfer requirements.

European Union — status at August 2026

The proposed ePrivacy Regulation that would have replaced the 2002 Directive was withdrawn. The intention was announced in the Commission's 2025 Work Programme on **11 February 2025**, the withdrawal was formally approved on 16 July 2025, and it was published in the Official Journal on 6 October 2025. The Directive, as amended, remains the controlling instrument.

Note

Earlier revisions of this guide gave that withdrawal date as February 2026, a year out. Corrected in 2.3.5.

The Digital Omnibus package, which would move cookie rules into the GDPR itself as new Articles 88a and 88b, split in two. The AI Omnibus was adopted by the Council on 29 June 2026. The Data Omnibus — the half that matters here — remains in negotiation, and the Council's compromise text of 21 May 2026 deleted the cookie-consent relocation entirely. Final wording is expected no earlier than late 2026. **Single-click refusal, the six-month**

cooldown and the proposed low-risk exemptions are proposals only. Nothing to reconfigure.

On enforcement: in July 2026 the EDPB issued Binding Decision 1/2026, instructing a supervisory authority to decide a cookie-banner complaint on its merits rather than dismissing it as an abuse of process. The practical effect is that representative cookie-banner complaints are much harder to dispose of on procedural grounds.

United States — recent changes

Connecticut's amended privacy act took effect on 1 July 2026 and reaches considerably further than before. The threshold for being covered dropped to 35,000 consumers, and it disappears entirely for any business that processes sensitive data or sells personal data — so a small site can now be in scope. Sensitive data was widened to include neural data, government identifiers, financial account details and social security numbers. Connecticut SB 4 follows on 1 October 2026 with facial recognition rules, a flat ban on selling precise geolocation, revised treatment of publicly available information, and data broker registration from 1 January 2027.

Several amendments landed mid-2026. None changes the consent model, but all three narrow what may be done with data the banner governs:

Change	Effect
Maryland (1 July 2026)	"Precise geolocation" widened to cover a consumer, mobile device or vehicle within a 1,750-foot radius.
Virginia (1 July 2026)	Outright prohibition on selling or offering to sell precise geolocation information.
New Jersey (30 June 2026)	Bans the sale of sensitive data by any entity, with no consumer-volume threshold at all — so it reaches sites well below that state's own applicability thresholds.

Important

The direction of travel matters more than any single amendment. Sensitive categories — precise location above all — are moving from "opt-out with consent" to "may not be sold at all". An opt-out link does not satisfy a flat prohibition. If you sell or share location data, that is a question for your adviser rather than a banner setting.

Four new comprehensive laws were enacted in the 2026 session, bringing the total to 24: Oklahoma SB 546 and the Louisiana Data Privacy Act (both 1 January 2027), the Alabama Personal Data Protection Act (1 May 2027) and the Vermont Data Privacy and Online Surveillance Act (1 January 2028). All four follow the Virginia opt-out model, so no banner change is required — an opt-out link plus GPC covers them. Two carry provisions worth noting: Vermont requires the same AI training disclosure as Connecticut (see section 14), and Oklahoma treats pseudonymous data as personal data wherever it can reasonably be linked to a person, which brings cookie identifiers squarely into scope.

Note

This plugin does not provide age assurance or age gating. If your site is directed at children or teenagers, the minors' provisions in Arkansas and several other states need to be handled outside the consent banner.

India — DPDP phasing

The DPDP Rules 2025 were notified on 13 November 2025 and commence in three phases. The Data Protection Board was established immediately. From **13 November 2026** the Board may hear complaints, conduct inquiries and levy penalties, and Consent Manager registration opens — enforcement powers arrive six months *before* the full compliance deadline of **13 May 2027**, not alongside it.

Global Privacy Control (GPC)

GPC is a signal sent by the visitor's browser indicating a blanket opt-out of sale or sharing. The plugin reads this signal in the browser and treats it as a valid opt-out where the law recognises it, without the visitor needing to interact with the banner at all.

Good to know

Regional rules move constantly. The plugin's compliance notes are reviewed and refreshed with each release, so keeping up to date is the simplest way to stay current — there is nothing to reconfigure when a region's guidance changes.

14. AI & Model Training Disclosure

Connecticut was the first US state to require your privacy notice to say plainly whether personal data is collected, used or sold to train large language models. Vermont now imposes the same duty. The plugin gives you a simple way to answer that question accurately.

Note

Connecticut's requirement has been live since 1 July 2026. Vermont's Data Privacy and Online Surveillance Act carries the same obligation from 1 January 2028. This is now a pattern rather than a one-off, so the section is worth completing accurately even if Connecticut does not reach you. (*Vermont added in 2.3.5.*)

What the law asks

The requirement is short but demanding. To answer it truthfully you need to know three things: whether your own products train or fine-tune models on user data, whether any of your suppliers are permitted to use your data to improve their models, and whether you sell or license data to anyone building AI systems. A vague line about using data to improve services does not answer it.

Configuring the disclosure

- Open **MBR Cookie Consent** › **Settings** › **Advanced Consent** and find **AI / LLM Training Disclosure**.
- Tick the first box to include the section in your generated privacy policy.
- Then tick any of the three statements that apply to you — your own models, your vendors' models, or selling data into training datasets.
- Add an optional sentence of extra detail if it helps explain your position.
- Regenerate your privacy policy page so the new text appears — see section 15.

What gets written

If none of the three statements apply, the plugin writes a clear statement that you do not collect, use or sell personal data to train large language models. That is the correct answer for most sites, and it is worth stating plainly rather than staying silent. If any do apply, each one produces a short paragraph explaining it in plain language.

Important

Check before you tick. An inaccurate statement in a public privacy notice is not only a privacy law problem — it can also be treated as a deceptive business practice. The answer about vendors in particular usually requires reading your suppliers' terms, because many reserve the right to use customer data for model improvement by default.

Note

These settings are deliberately excluded from settings export and import. They drive a legal statement about your business's data practices, and carrying them to another site would publish a claim nobody there ever made. See section 21.

15. Privacy Policy & Cookie Policy Pages

The plugin can generate both a cookie policy and a privacy policy from your current settings, including the AI training disclosure. Both appear as cards on the Dashboard once created.

Generating and editing

- Use the **Generate** button on the Dashboard to create the page.
- Once a page exists, **Edit** opens it directly in the WordPress editor.
- **Regenerate** rewrites the content from your current settings.

What Regenerate does and does not touch

Regenerating rewrites only the page content. The title, URL, published status and author are left alone, so a published policy stays published at the same address — no broken links, and nothing silently reverts to draft. The previous version is saved as a revision first, so it can be recovered from the page editor if you need it back.

Note

An existing policy page is never rewritten automatically. If you change a setting that affects the policy — the AI training disclosure being the common one — you must regenerate the page for the new text to appear. If you have been editing a generated policy by hand, review it before regenerating: your manual edits will be replaced, though the previous version remains available as a revision.

16. Internationalisation & Community Translations

The banner can be shown in the visitor's own language, in 22 languages. Because a consent notice is a legal statement rather than ordinary interface text, this works differently from most translation features — nothing is shown to a visitor until you have read it and approved it.

Why the translations need your approval

The translations are contributed rather than professionally produced, and they have not been checked by a qualified translator or a lawyer. A cookie banner tells visitors what you collect and what they are agreeing to. An approximate translation of ordinary interface text is a minor annoyance; an approximate translation of a consent notice is a compliance risk, and it is your site that carries it.

So nothing is served automatically. Each language has to be read and approved individually, and until it is, visitors asking for that language see your own wording — which is text you wrote and can stand behind.

Reviewing and approving a language

- Open **MBR Cookie Consent > Translations** for the list of available languages and their status.
- Select **Review** beside a language to see every string with your English beside the translation.
- Read it. Right-to-left languages are displayed in the correct direction.
- Tick the confirmation and select **Approve**. The confirmation is required — approval is refused without it.
- Enable **Auto-Translation** under Settings once at least one language is approved.

Approval can be withdrawn at any time, and takes effect immediately.

Tip

Approve the languages you or a colleague can actually read, and leave the rest. Six approved languages covering most of your traffic is a better position than twenty-two nobody has checked, and the unapproved ones cost you nothing — those visitors simply see your own wording.

Your own wording is never overwritten

If you have rewritten a string — your own banner heading, say — it is never replaced by a translation. There is no community translation of your wording, and showing your actual words in English is more accurate than showing a generic sentence in French that says something subtly different. Customised strings are marked as such on the review screen.

How the language is chosen

The visitor's browser language settings are used, taking the first of their preferred languages that you have approved. Regional variants share a language: a visitor asking for Brazilian Portuguese is served the Portuguese translation. The swap happens in the browser, not on the server — choosing a language while building the page would write one visitor's language into a copy that a cache then serves to everybody.

Available languages

Region	Languages
Western Europe	French, German, Spanish, Italian, Portuguese, Dutch
Northern Europe	Swedish, Danish, Norwegian, Finnish
Central & Eastern Europe	Polish, Czech, Russian, Greek
Asia	Japanese, Chinese, Korean, Thai, Vietnamese
Middle East	Arabic, Hebrew, Turkish

WPML and Polylang

Full string registration for WPML and Polylang is unchanged by the above. Where a multilingual plugin is active it takes precedence for its own languages, since it varies the page address and is therefore safe to apply while building the page. Community translations fill in for visitors whose language your multilingual setup does not cover.

Important

In your site's default language, the plugin's own setting is authoritative. If you previously worked around older behaviour by editing your default-language wording in WPML's String Translation screen, the plugin's setting now overrides it. Check your banner in the default language after updating.

17. Accessibility

The banner and Preference Centre are built to WCAG 2.1 AA so that consent is genuinely available to every visitor, not just those using a mouse.

- Full keyboard navigation throughout the banner and Preference Centre.
- Screen reader support with appropriate ARIA roles and labels.
- A focus trap keeps keyboard focus within the modal while it is open.
- Visible focus indicators so keyboard users always know where they are.

- Visitors who have asked their system for reduced transparency are served a solid banner surface rather than the glass effect.

The WCAG/ADA Compliance switch

These enhancements are controlled by **Enable WCAG/ADA Compliance Features**, under Settings > Int'l & Accessibility. It is on by default, and there is rarely a good reason to turn it off.

Important

This switch did not work before version 2.3.5. Ticking it and saving returned a page with the box clear again, which looked exactly like the save had failed — and unticking it did not switch anything off either, because the accessibility layer carried on running regardless. The screen was reporting the opposite of the truth in both directions. It now saves, displays and applies correctly. Sites updating are set to **on**, which is what they were actually doing all along.

Tip

If you heavily restyle the banner colours, re-check contrast afterwards. Accessibility is built in, but custom colours are your responsibility to keep within AA contrast ratios — the live readout described in section 6 is the quickest way to confirm it.

18. Consent Logging & Records of Consent

Being able to demonstrate consent is as important as collecting it. The plugin keeps a record of every consent interaction.

- Each interaction is logged with its timestamp and the categories chosen.
- IP addresses are anonymised in line with GDPR data-handling expectations. IPv6 addresses are truncated by 80 bits, which removes enough of the address to prevent a household being identified.
- Records are exportable to CSV for your own audit and retention processes.
- Old records can be pruned on demand; the plugin asks for confirmation first and refuses a retention period below one day.

The visitor fingerprint

Alongside the anonymised IP address, each row carries a one-way fingerprint derived from the visitor's IP address and browser identification string. It lets repeat interactions from the same visitor be grouped without keeping the raw address.

Important

Hardened in 2.3.5. This fingerprint was previously an unsalted SHA-256. Both inputs are drawn from a small enough range — the IPv4 address space is finite and browser identification strings come from a short list — that anyone holding an exported log could recover the original address by working through every possibility. That made it a pseudonymous identifier rather than the anonymisation it appeared to be. It is now keyed with a salt unique to your site that never leaves your server.

Note

Rows written before 2.3.5 will not match rows written after it, because the salt changes the value. Nothing in the plugin queries or joins on this column, so the only consequence is a discontinuity in the history. The network CSV export column is also now headed **Visitor Hash** rather than *Cookie Hash*: it has never been a hash of the consent cookie, and a compliance export should not mislabel its own columns.

Good to know

The logging endpoint accepts unauthenticated requests by design, because a nonce baked into cached HTML goes stale and would block genuine consent records. It is throttled per visitor so the log cannot be flooded with junk rows, and category names are validated against the categories your site has actually registered. CSV exports are protected against spreadsheet formula injection, since a value beginning with `=`, `+`, `-` or `@` is executed as a formula by Excel, LibreOffice and Sheets.

Important

Consent records written before version 2.3.3 have an unreliable **Method** column — every row was recorded as “other”. The categories, timestamps and everything else in those rows are sound, but the Method column cannot be reconstructed.

Important

Consent records are personal data. Store any exports securely, keep them only as long as you need them, and include them in your own data retention and deletion routines. They are deliberately excluded from the settings export described in section 21, and are never removed by a plugin update, by deactivation, or even by deleting the plugin — removing that data is always a deliberate act on your part.

19. A/B Testing

A/B testing lets you compare banner variations to see which earns clearer, higher-quality consent. Visitors are assigned at random to one of three banner layouts, and the plugin records how many saw each and how many accepted.

- Test wording, layout or button styling against each other.
- Compare acceptance behaviour between the variants.
- Adopt the stronger performer once you have enough data.

A/B testing is **off by default**. Enable it under **MBR Cookie Consent › A/B Testing**.

How assignment works

From version 2.3.5, the variant is chosen in the visitor's browser and stored in a session cookie, so it persists across page views and clears when the browser closes. The page itself is identical for every visitor, which is what makes it safe to cache.

Important

A/B testing did not work behind a page cache before 2.3.5. The variant was chosen on the server and written into the page, so whichever visitor happened to generate the cached copy had their variant baked into it, and everyone served that copy afterwards saw the same one. Impressions were recorded against the cached variant rather than the visitor's. If you have run a test on a cached site, those figures describe your cache rather than your visitors — **reset your statistics before drawing any conclusions from them**.

Note

Because the variant is now assigned in the browser, the `mbr_cc_ab_variant` cookie is no longer `HttpOnly` — the script that assigns it has to be able to read it back. It is a session cookie holding a single letter naming a banner layout, and no personal data.

Important

Statistics gathered before version 2.3.1 are also overstated for a separate reason: impressions were counted on every page load rather than once per visitor. Conversions are now deduplicated per visitor over 24 hours.

Promoting a winner

Once a variant has enough data, **Promote winner** writes its layout into your banner settings and switches A/B testing off. Your page cache is purged so the change appears immediately.

Note

Before 2.3.5, promoting variant B or C wrote a layout name into the banner *position* setting — a combination the appearance picker cannot represent, so it showed no layout selected and the next save on that screen quietly reset it. If you promoted a winner on an earlier version, check the Appearance screen shows the layout you expect.

Note

Optimise for clarity and informed choice, not for the highest possible Accept rate. A banner engineered purely to maximise acceptance can undermine the validity of the consent you collect.

20. Multisite Support

On a WordPress Multisite network, MBR Cookie Consent is network-aware and adjusts its settings across sites automatically.

- Activate across the network, or per individual site, as you prefer.
- Apply a consistent baseline configuration to every site on the network.
- Allow individual sites to keep their own settings where they differ.
- New sites added to the network pick up the network configuration automatically.

Note

Network settings are shared, but page caches are not — each site holds its own. Saving network settings purges the cache of the site you saved from; other sites pick the change up as their own caches expire, or immediately if an administrator saves there. See section 22.

Tip

For separate installs that are not part of a Multisite network, use the settings export and import described in the next section to keep their configuration aligned.

21. Importing & Exporting Settings

Settings import and export lets you configure one site exactly as you want it, then reproduce that configuration on any number of other installs — without re-keying a single field. It was built for multi-site rollouts and for keeping a repeatable, auditable baseline.

Exporting a configuration

- Go to **MBR Cookie Consent > Import / Export**.
- Select **Download settings file**.
- A single JSON file is produced, named after your site and the date.

- The file carries a short header — plugin version, source site, timestamp and an integrity checksum — alongside the settings themselves.

What travels with the file

Category	Detail
Included	Banner appearance and text, glassmorphism opacity and blur, dark mode, the logo URL, banner behaviour, cookie categories, blocked scripts, Google and Microsoft Consent Mode, GPC, form integration, page exclusions, custom CSS, subdomain sharing, policy link toggles and URLs, and all geolocation regional headings and descriptions.
Never included	Consent logs. These are visitor personal data and stay with the site that collected them — use the CSV export on the Consent Logs screen instead.
Site-local, excluded	Policy page IDs, the geolocation lookup cache, version markers, the logo's Media Library attachment ID, the visitor IP detection mode and trusted proxy list, the ip-api.com pro key, the plain-HTTP geolocation opt-in, the AI training disclosure settings, and the list of approved community translations.

Why those exclusions matter

Each excluded value is a fact about one specific site rather than a preference you would want to reproduce. An attachment ID refers to a different image, or none at all, on another install. Which proxy a site sits behind is a property of that server, and importing it elsewhere can silently break geolocation. A credential should not ride along in a file that gets emailed around. An approved translation records that a particular person read that language and took responsibility for publishing it, which is not a responsibility that transfers with a settings file. Agencies templating many sites for one client can opt any of these back in with the `mbr_cc_site_local_settings` filter.

Importing on another site

- On the destination site, open the same screen and choose the file.
- Tick the confirmation box, then select **Import settings**.
- Matching settings are overwritten. A short report shows how many were applied and whether anything was ignored.
- Your page cache is purged automatically once the import completes.

Undoing an import

- Before an import is applied, the plugin automatically backs up the settings that are about to change.
- **Revert last import** restores them in a single step, and purges the cache again.
- Only the most recent import can be reverted — a later import replaces the stored backup. Treat it as a safety net, not a version history.

Note

Import replaces rather than merges. Settings absent from the file are left alone, but cookie categories and blocked scripts, when present, replace the existing sets in full. The importer only accepts settings it recognises, and every value is re-validated before it is stored, so an edited or corrupted file cannot introduce unexpected data into your site.

22. Caching & Performance

The plugin is **safe to run behind a page cache**. That sounds like a small claim, and getting there took three releases.

The problem, and how it was fixed

A page cache stores one copy of a page and serves it to everybody. Anything the server writes into that page based on who is asking will therefore be served to everyone who follows. Over 2.3.3, 2.3.4 and 2.3.5 every such case was moved into the browser:

What used to vary on the server	Fixed in
Script and iframe blocking, decided from the visitor's consent cookie	2.3.3
Google and Microsoft Consent Mode defaults	2.3.3
Global Privacy Control state	2.3.3
Banner language	2.3.3
Regional banner wording and behaviour	2.3.4
The 'Do Not Sell or Share' link	2.3.4
A/B testing variant assignment	2.3.5

Nothing that varies by visitor is now written into the page. Every visitor receives an identical document with all non-necessary scripts and embeds held, a denied consent default, and no GPC or regional state at all. Their own choice is applied in their browser. The page is therefore identical whoever generates it, which is precisely what makes it safe to cache.

Good to know

This also made the plugin faster on cached sites. The rewriting work now happens once per cache miss rather than once per visitor, and each blocked service is checked with a plain substring test before any pattern matching runs. A page with no third-party embeds costs roughly a single scan.

Purging on save

Saving your settings purges the page cache automatically, so a change to the banner shows up straight away instead of waiting for the cache to expire — which used to look exactly like the save had failed. This covers the settings screen, cookie categories, blocked scripts, the form integration message, Custom CSS, settings import and revert, and promoting an A/B winner.

- SiteGround Speed Optimizer · WP Rocket · LiteSpeed Cache · W3 Total Cache
- WP Super Cache · WP Fastest Cache · WP-Optimize · Cache Enabler
- Breeze · Nginx Helper · WP Engine

What it deliberately does not touch

- **Your PHP opcode cache.** OPcache stores compiled PHP files and is only relevant when a file on disk changes, which saving a setting does not do.
- **Minified assets.** The banner stylesheet does not change when you save; its colours are emitted inline.
- **Your object cache.** Redis and Memcached hold the geolocation lookup cache, which is keyed per visitor address and expires on its own.

Note

If your host purges on its own schedule, or your agency controls purging from a deploy script, the behaviour can be turned off with the `mbr_cc_flush_caches` filter. There are also `mbr_cc_before_flush_caches` and `mbr_cc_flush_caches_after` actions for hooking your own cache layer in, and `mbr_cc_cache_ignored_options` for excluding particular settings.

23. CCPA and ‘Do Not Sell or Share’

For visitors in California and other US states with similar laws, the plugin can display the required opt-out mechanism.

- An optional **Do Not Sell or Share My Personal Information** link is available.
- Selecting it records the visitor’s opt-out and applies it to the relevant categories.
- Browser-level Global Privacy Control signals are honoured as a valid opt-out automatically, decided in the browser so a cached page cannot carry one visitor’s signal to everybody.

24. Troubleshooting & FAQ

The WCAG/ADA switch will not stay ticked

Fixed in 2.3.5. The setting was stored as a word rather than a yes/no value, so the checkbox never recognised it on the way back in — and the features could not be turned off either, because the same stored word counted as a yes on the front end. Update, and the switch will save, display and apply correctly.

My A/B test shows everyone the same variant

If you run a page cache, this was the fault fixed in 2.3.5 — the variant was decided on the server, so the first visitor through primed the cache with theirs. Update, purge your caches, and reset your statistics, because the figures gathered before the fix describe the cache rather than your visitors.

The banner does not appear

You have most likely already recorded a consent choice in your current browser. Test in a private / incognito window, or clear the plugin’s stored consent for your site, and the banner will return.

My YouTube or Vimeo embed plays without consent

If you run a performance plugin with a video lazy-load or facade option, this is almost certainly the cause and it is fixed in 2.3.3. Update, purge your caches, and test again with cookies rejected — you should see the blocked-content placeholder in place of the video.

My banner changes are not showing on the front end

The page cache is purged automatically when you save, so this should resolve itself. If a change still does not appear, clear your browser cache first — it sits outside anything the plugin can reach. Then confirm your caching plugin is one of those listed in section 22; if it is not, purge it manually and let me know which one you use so it can be added.

The wrong region's banner appears

This was fixed in 2.3.4, when region resolution moved into the browser. If it persists after updating, check that your server can reach your geolocation provider at all — if outbound requests are blocked or rate-limited, every lookup falls back to your default region. Switching to Cloudflare headers, where available, removes the outbound call entirely.

Everyone sees the same region behind my CDN

Check **Visitor IP Detection** under Geolocation. The default, Automatic, believes Cloudflare’s header only when the request genuinely came from a Cloudflare address. If you sit behind a different proxy or load balancer, set the mode to **Trusted proxies** and supply its addresses, otherwise every visitor appears to arrive from the proxy itself.

My translated banner is still in English

Check three things in order. Automatic translation must be enabled under Settings; at least one language must be approved on the Translations screen; and the visitor's browser must be asking for a language you have approved. A language that is available but not approved is deliberately not served. Strings you have rewritten yourself are also never translated, which is intentional.

Scripts still load before consent

Check that the script is known to the plugin — run the scanner again and confirm it is listed and categorised. Hard-coded scripts placed directly in the theme may need to be added manually. Also confirm no other plugin is loading the script outside the consent layer.

Forms submit before consent is given

Confirm the form's required consent category is set under Form Builder Integration, and that the form plugin is one of the supported builders. Then test the full submit-block-accept-resubmit cycle in a private window.

The AI training section is missing from my privacy policy

The section only appears if you have enabled it under Advanced Consent, and the policy page must be regenerated after you change the setting. An existing policy page is not rewritten automatically — use the **Regenerate** button on the Dashboard.

My site is never offered an update

Before version 2.3.2 the update manifest declared minimums of PHP 8.0 and WordPress 6.0, while the plugin itself supports PHP 7.4 and WordPress 5.8. The manifest is what decides whether an update is offered, so sites on those older versions were told no update was available. Install 2.3.2 or later by hand once, and automatic updates will work from then on.

Does this plugin slow my site down?

The consent layer is lightweight and loads early so it can block trackers on the first view. If you also run a performance plugin that delays JavaScript, make sure the consent script is excluded from delay so it is ready before trackers attempt to fire.

25. Support, Feedback & Resources

Your feedback shapes the plugin. Bug reports are fixed quickly, and the best new features come from real users describing what they need — the import and export feature began exactly that way, version 2.3.3 exists because someone took the time to report that their apostrophes kept multiplying, and 2.3.5 exists because someone noticed a checkbox that would not stay ticked.

Resource	Where
Plugin home	littlewebshack.com/mbr-cookie-consent/
Source & issues	github.com/HarbourBob/MBR-Cookie-Consent
Email	info@littlewebshack.com
More plugins & dev tools	littlewebshack.com

Whether you have a question, a bug to report, a feature idea, or simply want to say the plugin saved you a subscription — every message is read and valued. Together we are building the best consent manager for WordPress.

Good to know

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